The Walking Dead as an Ontology of Unfinished Death

gnalens

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I. Introduction — Theoretical Frame and Research Question

The zombie has long been available to cultural analysis as a figure of mediation between social fear and bodily disorder. Popular criticism treats it as allegory: the colonial residue of the zonbi, the symptom of capitalist consumption, the vector of viral modernity. Yet the very elasticity that allows the zombie to serve all such functions indicates a deeper constancy that allegory cannot exhaust. Across historical, cultural, and formal variation, the zombie remains recognizable even as its representational referents change. This persistence suggests that the zombie is not merely a metaphorical form but an **ontological invariant**: a configuration of being that continues to recur wherever life is organized through its own preservation.[**DescribingZombie**]

The present study applies the ontological framework developed in **Describing the Zombie: Toward an Ontology of Unfinished Death** to the television series **The Walking Dead** (AMC, 2010–2022). It proceeds from the claim advanced there—that the zombie is best understood as vitality minus reflexivity, or life deprived of its capacity to relate to finitude—and examines how this structure governs not only the undead but every living form within the series. The goal is not to interpret the show's monsters symbolically but to demonstrate that the series as a whole constitutes a field experiment in what the earlier paper called "unfinished death": the condition in which life continues beyond its capacity to end.

This approach requires a methodological shift. Instead of locating meaning in narrative representation, it treats **The Walking Dead** as an empirical manifestation of theoretical systems articulated in modern continental thought. Foucault's analysis of biopower and Agamben's of bare life supply the initial parameters: life as an object of administrative control and

life as inclusion through exclusion. Mbembe's concept of necropolitics extends these parameters to the management of death as a political resource. Esposito's immunitary paradigm and Haraway's posthuman elaborations describe the mechanisms by which systems of life incorporate death to preserve themselves. Canguilhem's account of normativity and pathology specifies the biological correlate of this logic—life that functions without the power to set new norms—while Simondon's philosophy of individuation identifies the ontological threshold at which relation fails and energy persists without form. Finally, Berlant's theory of slow death provides a phenomenological register for this suspension: time stretched into maintenance, affect flattened into endurance.

The convergence of these theoretical vectors defines the operative concept of this study: unfinished death. In such a condition, survival ceases to signify continuation of life and becomes its own form of governance. The zombie, as articulated in **Describing the Zombie**, is not an aberration within life but the point at which the biopolitical project of making-live achieves its logical completion. The question that follows—and that motivates the present analysis—is therefore not "What does **The Walking Dead** say about the zombie?" but "How does **The Walking Dead** demonstrate that the living already are the zombie?"

To answer this, the essay undertakes a systematic analysis organized through the principal stages of the earlier ontology: (1) the biopolitical and necropolitical structuring of life; (2) the immunitary and pathological mechanisms that sustain it; (3) the phenomenology of time, affect, and relation under such conditions; and (4) the ontological synthesis whereby governance becomes the ground of being. Each stage will be traced within the series through specific narrative sites—the hospital, the farm, the prison, the horde, and the Commonwealth—where theoretical categories become diegetic realities.

By reading **The Walking Dead** through this framework, the study aims to clarify how the contemporary zombie genre renders visible the transformation of politics into biology and of biology into ontology. The show's duration, repetition, and exhaustion are not defects of serial television but formal correlates of the world it depicts: a world in which existence has outlasted its relational capacity. In this sense, **The Walking Dead** is not a representation of the zombie condition but its enactment—a medium in which unfinished death achieves narrative form.

II. Ontological Preliminaries: Life, Relation, and Negation

Before turning to **The Walking Dead** as a text, it is necessary to specify what is meant here by life. Within the framework developed in **Describing the Zombie**, life is not an empirical category but a formal relation between vitality and reflexivity. Vitality denotes the self-sustaining activity of an organism—metabolic, biological, or systemic continuity—whereas reflexivity designates the capacity of that organism to relate to its own finitude, to constitute itself as a being that can end. In this formulation, the living is not defined by mere motion or persistence but by its ability to form a relation to negation. To live, in the full ontological sense, is to include death within the field of relation as the condition of meaning.

This model follows a long philosophical lineage. For Hegel, life realizes itself through the labor of the negative: being is not self-identical but becomes through contradiction. Heidegger reformulates this as being-toward-death, the existential structure by which Dasein appropriates finitude as its own-most possibility. Canguilhem's biological writings translate this dynamic into the register of the organism: health is not equilibrium but the power to institute new norms through exposure to the world's variability. Simondon extends the argument further, defining individuation as the process through which pre-individual energy resolves itself by forming relations across a milieu. Each of these accounts presupposes that relation to negation—whether as death, disease, or tension—is constitutive of life.

The zombie interrupts this logic at its core. It is vitality without reflexivity, persistence that has lost the capacity to relate to negation. Its body metabolizes, moves, and decomposes, yet no act within it acknowledges the possibility of cessation. The zombie neither resists nor accepts death; it simply fails to encounter it. This structural blindness to finitude distinguishes undeath from both life and death. Death is the closure of relation; undeath is the disappearance of relation itself. The zombie thus occupies the ontological remainder between being and nothingness: an existence that continues because it cannot end.

In the modern context, this remainder is not confined to the monstrous or supernatural. It is produced systematically within what Foucault names biopower: the apparatus through which states, institutions, and technologies manage life at the level of population and species. When life becomes an object of governance, its reflexive dimension is displaced by administrative logic. Survival replaces meaning; maintenance replaces relation. Agamben's

notion of bare life names the same condition in juridical terms: life included in the political order only through its exclusion from rights, a life that can be killed but not sacrificed. Mbembe's subsequent concept of necropolitics makes explicit the consequence of this inclusion: the production of death-worlds where populations are maintained in a state of being-dead.

Within this theoretical constellation, the zombie ceases to be a metaphor and becomes an ontological index. It reveals what life becomes when governance replaces relation and survival supplants mortality as the measure of value. The Haitian zonbi, whose body labors without will; the cinematic revenant, whose hunger repeats without satisfaction; and the viral infected, whose movement propagates without intention—all instantiate the same formal structure: the persistence of vitality after the collapse of relation to negation. In every case, undeath is not an intrusion into life but the form that life assumes under conditions of total administration.

This framework provides the analytic ground for what follows. The aim is to trace, within **The Walking Dead**, the gradual realization of this ontological condition across scales: from the individual body to the community, from the temporal rhythm of episodes to the formal logic of the series itself. Each stage of the analysis will therefore proceed by identifying the point at which reflexivity fails and vitality continues—where life ceases to be capable of ending and thus becomes indistinguishable from its own management. In doing so, the series will be shown to operate not as an allegory of the zombie but as an environment in which the zombie ontology is the organizing principle of all existence.

III. Biopower and Bare Life in "Days Gone Bye"

The opening episode of **The Walking Dead** constitutes the series' ontological ground state: it dramatizes, in visual and spatial form, the displacement of life's reflexivity by the administrative apparatus of modern biopolitics. The narrative situation—Rick Grimes' awakening from a coma into a depopulated hospital—stages the transformation of the living body into an object of management, while simultaneously rendering visible the juridical paradox that Agamben calls bare life: life included within the law solely through its exclusion from political meaning.

1. The Hospital as Biopolitical Machine

From its first frame, the mise-en-scène is disciplinary. The shot composition reproduces the architectural logic that Foucault attributes to the modern

hospital and prison: surveillance corridors, enclosed wards, segmentation of bodies by function. Rick's body is already contained within the grid of what Foucault calls anatomo-politics, the management of individual life through normalization. The flickering fluorescent light and the steady cardiac monitor stand in for a state that continues to administer even in absence. When Rick removes his intravenous line, the gesture is not rebellion but the mechanical detachment of a body from its support system; the institution's power persists through the residual order it has left imprinted on his movements.

The hallway sequence that follows externalizes this logic. The camera tracks Rick down a long corridor, its vanishing point terminating in a padlocked metal door painted with the contradictory injunction "Don't Open, Dead Inside." The sign operates as a biopolitical proposition: a command that protects by excluding. Those "inside" remain within the space of life only through containment; those "outside" live only through avoidance. The door is both quarantine and threshold, a material instance of what Foucault terms the caesura of the living: the separation of the manageable from the unmanageable body.

2. Bare Life and the Inclusive Exclusion

Agamben's formulation of bare life clarifies the juridical dimension of this structure. The locked cafeteria and the bodies within it represent a population placed simultaneously inside and outside the order of law. Their containment signifies their continued inclusion—they are still subjects of regulation—but their exclusion from visibility and communication annuls political recognition. The warning on the door becomes a declaration of sovereign authority: the decision concerning who may appear as human. Rick's hesitation before the door registers his passage into Agamben's "zone of indistinction," where the categories of life and death no longer stabilize.

When he steps outside the hospital and into the field of corpses strewn before the service ramp, the camera adopts a high aerial perspective, transforming the dead into a managed landscape. The world has become a morgue administered by absence. The scene visualizes the extension of the camp—Agamben's paradigmatic space of exception—into the entire social field. The hospital, the street, and the town all operate according to the same logic: governance through abandonment.

3. The Half-Bodied Woman and the Ontology of Remainder

Rick's encounter with the crawling half-bodied walker provides the episode's clearest articulation of the zombie's ontological status. The figure embodies vitality without relation: motion without mobility, persistence without horizon. Her body has been divided—upper torso animate, lower half absent—yet the remaining musculature continues its repetitive advance. She is neither dying nor living; she is the process of continuation itself. From the perspective of the earlier ontology, she is vitality deprived of reflexivity, existence that cannot complete its own negation.

Rick's reaction to this encounter establishes the series' ethical register. Rather than horror, he expresses recognition: "I'm sorry this happened to you." The line acknowledges a shared ontological condition. His pity marks the reappearance, within the biopolitical landscape, of a momentary reflexivity—life addressing itself through its own remainder. Yet this relation is immediately foreclosed; the camera pulls back, the shot lingers on her crawling body, and the scene closes without resolution. The possibility of relation is observed only to be withdrawn.

4. From Administration to World

Taken together, these sequences instantiate the conversion of biopolitical management into world-structure. The hospital, the door, and the half-bodied woman collectively diagram the transformation of life into process. What was once the machinery of care persists as the machinery of endurance. No new political order replaces the old; governance itself has become the environment. The episode therefore performs, rather than narrates, the transition from life as relation to life as administration—the shift that **Describing the Zombie** identifies as the defining movement of modernity toward unfinished death.

Within this framework, Rick's awakening is not the beginning of a hero's journey but the ontological event of entry into the biopolitical real. His survival is the form through which the world demonstrates its own continuity. In Foucault's terms, he awakens not after the state but inside its ultimate extension: a regime where the management of life has outlived its subjects. The series begins, then, not with apocalypse but with the full revelation of a world already structured as the administration of its own remainder.

IV. Necropolitics, Immunity, and the Pathology of Survival

If the hospital episode establishes the world of **The Walking Dead** as a biopolitical environment, the second major locus—the farm arc of the second season—clarifies how this world administers life through death. Here the survivors' temporary refuge at Hershel Greene's farm functions as a microcosm of the necropolitical and immunitary mechanisms that sustain modern governance. The narrative crisis surrounding the barn and the figures imprisoned within it translates the theoretical operations described by Mbembe, Esposito, and Canguilhem into diegetic and visual form.

1. The Barn as Necropolitical Enclosure

In **Necropolitics** (2003), Achille Mbembe reformulates Foucault's concept of biopower to emphasize the ways in which the governance of life necessarily entails the governance of death. Where biopower seeks to make live and let die, necropower operates by maintaining life in a state of being-dead. The barn on Hershel's property literalizes this logic. It houses a population of animated corpses—Hershel's family members and neighbors—whom he regards not as monsters but as "sick people." They are maintained, fed, and confined. His gesture, ostensibly compassionate, reproduces the necropolitical condition: the retention of vitality in the absence of political or moral personhood. The barn thereby becomes a death-world in Mbembe's sense—a zone in which existence continues under the administration of others, suspended between elimination and preservation.

When the survivors discover the barn's contents, the conflict that follows is not between belief and disbelief but between two modes of sovereignty. Hershel's paternal authority maintains life through containment; Shane's insurgent authority reasserts power through execution. Both forms are variants of necropolitical governance. Whether the living-dead are managed or destroyed, the underlying structure remains identical: the reduction of life to a material that can be regulated.

2. The Mass Execution and the Logic of Immunity

Roberto Esposito's **Immunitas** (2002) provides the conceptual mechanism linking this necropolitical scene to the broader ontological field. For Esposito, the social body preserves itself by internalizing a controlled form of its own negation; immunity is the inclusion of death as a safeguard for

life. The massacre at the barn visualizes the moment this mechanism becomes self-destructive. When Shane forces open the doors and the group begins shooting, the action is presented as procedural rather than heroic: an act of sanitary disposal. The survivors protect themselves by absorbing the sovereign prerogative of killing into ordinary life. Immunity collapses into autoimmunity.

The scene's cinematography underscores this transformation. Each gunshot is filmed as part of a regulated rhythm; the camera cuts evenly between bodies falling and weapons reloading. The image resembles not combat but administration—a sequence of regulated operations maintaining the boundary of the living. When Sophia, the missing child, emerges from the barn as the final walker, the immunitary paradox is fully revealed. The community's act of purification returns its own member as contaminant. The fence between life and death collapses from within.

Rick's execution of Sophia, performed in silence and without affect, closes the immunitary loop. His gesture is neither murder nor mercy; it is the technical act by which the social organism re-establishes its self-identity. The scene thereby demonstrates Esposito's thesis that modern life sustains itself only through the incorporation of death as function. The survivor community persists by becoming the apparatus that produces its own dead.

3. Pathology and the Loss of Normativity

The repetitive life on the farm—feeding animals, tending crops, maintaining fences—reflects the biological dimension of this logic as analyzed by Georges Canguilhem in **The Normal and the Pathological** (1943). For Canguilhem, health is not equilibrium but the capacity to generate new norms of functioning. Pathology arises when an organism continues to operate but can no longer institute new values for its activity. The farm community, seemingly pastoral and restorative, embodies this pathological condition. Its routines sustain vitality without transformation. Each day reproduces the same pattern of maintenance; the survivors live but cannot live otherwise.

Hershel's belief that the walkers are "ill" rather than dead extends this pathology into ontology. He treats undeath as a curable deviation from the norm, thereby reaffirming the norm itself. Yet the world of the series has already withdrawn the ground on which normativity stands. The persistence of the undead is not an exception to life but its new mode. The survivors' insistence on cure and containment thus functions as denial of the fact that life has lost its normative capacity. In Canguilhem's terms, they remain alive only as the continuation of the pathological state itself.

4. Ontological Consolidation

The farm arc therefore marks the point at which **The Walking Dead** completes its passage from biopolitical administration to necropolitical ontology. Life is no longer governed for its improvement but sustained through its own suspension. The barn scene, in particular, integrates the theoretical axes of Mbembe, Esposito, and Canguilhem into a single configuration:

- Necropolitical form: life maintained in death-world (the barn).
- Immunitary mechanism: self-preservation through controlled killing (the massacre).
- Pathological condition: survival without normative renewal (the farm).

Together these operations instantiate the condition defined in **Describing the Zombie** as unfinished death: vitality deprived of reflexivity, persistence maintained through its own negation. By the close of the arc, the survivors' community has internalized the logic of undeath it sought to resist. The barn's destruction is not a restoration of order but the absorption of necropolitical governance into the structure of everyday life.

From this point onward, **The Walking Dead** ceases to differentiate clearly between the living and the dead. Both operate according to the same ontological principle—self-preservation through the repetition of management. The zombie condition has become the universal condition of the world.

V. Immunity, Auto-Immunity, and the Failure of Individuation

The movement from Hershel's farm to the abandoned prison reorganizes the survivors' world along explicitly immunitary lines. The prison is not a site of safety but a diagram of Esposito's thesis that life sustains itself through internalized negation. Its architecture—fences, gates, cellblocks, surveillance towers—renders the biological distinction between inside and outside as material infrastructure. If the farm represented the necropolitical enclosure of the dead, the prison represents the immunitary enclosure of the living. In both cases, survival is achieved by reproducing the logic of containment that defines death itself.

1. The Prison as Immune Architecture

The visual grammar of the prison arc makes Esposito's concept legible without paraphrase. Overhead crane shots emphasize separation of zones: the inner yard, the perimeter fence, the outer fields. Each movement between these spaces requires a ritual of purification—unlocking gates, checking for contamination, burning corpses. Life is lived as the repetition of border maintenance. In Esposito's terms, community (communitas) has been replaced by immunity (immunitas): the preservation of the collective through the continual reaffirmation of its own boundaries.

The immune paradigm reaches its critical threshold with the outbreak of influenza inside the prison. The disease collapses the spatial distinction on which survival depends, transforming protection into vulnerability. Carol's decision to kill Karen and David before their infection spreads is the pure enactment of auto-immunity: the body politic destroys part of itself to defend itself. Her act is neither malicious nor arbitrary; it is the immune reflex raised to the level of ethics. By the logic of Esposito's analysis, the community's principle of life has become its principle of death. The cremation that follows—smoke rising above the yard—is the visual condensation of that paradox: the immune system purging itself to remain whole.

2. Woodbury and the Necropolitical Counter-Image

Running parallel to the prison, the Governor's fortified town of Woodbury extends Mbembe's necropolitical sovereignty into civic form. Where the prison operates through internal negation, Woodbury maintains vitality by externalizing death: the gladiatorial arena where captured walkers are used for spectacle and discipline. Both sites are governed by identical logics of immunitary preservation; they differ only in whether the violence is introjected or projected. The eventual war between the two communities is thus not a clash of values but an autoimmune confrontation—life attacking its own reflection. When the Governor drives a tank through the prison's gates, the metaphor becomes literal: the immune barrier is destroyed by the defensive apparatus designed to secure it.

3. Simondon and the Failure of Individuation

Gilbert Simondon's philosophy of individuation provides the ontological description of what these immunitary mechanisms produce. For Simondon, an individual is not a static entity but a process through which pre-individual

potential is resolved via relation with its milieu. Individuation therefore requires openness; relation is its constitutive operation. Auto-immunity, by contrast, forecloses relation. When every outside is treated as threat, individuation halts, and energy circulates without resolution—a state Simondon terms metastable.

The prison community exhibits precisely this condition. Its daily life is energetic but non-productive: constant vigilance, repeated repairs, endless decision-making that leads nowhere. The survivors' identities—farmer, soldier, doctor—are functional designations, not individuations. They operate as parts of a system maintaining its own stasis. The zombie horde, viewed through this lens, is not the community's opposite but its isomorphic double: a field of bodies moving together without relation, metastable energy propagated through repetition. Both formations lack what Simondon calls transductive relation, the dynamic through which new forms emerge.

4. Ontological Equivalence of Living and Dead

The prison narrative culminates in the realization that immunitary life and undead life share an identical structure. When the fences collapse under the weight of walkers, the camera alternates between close-ups of human faces and decomposing ones, erasing categorical distinction. The same collective motion—pushing, shouting, firing—governs both sides of the barrier. The sequence visually confirms what **Describing the Zombie** posited conceptually: that undeath is not exterior to life but the form life assumes when relation has been supplanted by management.

5. Synthesis

The prison and Governor arcs together exhibit the convergence of Esposito's and Simondon's frameworks:

Theoretical Operator	Manifestation	Ontological Function
Immunitas (Esposito)	Fences, quarantines, purges	Preservation through internalized nega
Auto-immunity	Carol's killings, internal disease	Self-destruction as defense
Individuation (Simondon)	Daily maintenance routines	Relation reduced to system operation
Metastability	Human and walker collectives	Energy without differentiation

Through these mechanisms, **The Walking Dead** advances from the necropolitical management of death (the farm) to the immunitary and ontological management of life itself. Survival has become an end without object;

the community endures by reproducing the conditions of its own exhaustion. At this juncture, the distinction between the living and the dead is ontologically obsolete. Both exist as instances of the same process—vitality deprived of reflexivity, relation replaced by operation.

VI. Phenomenology of Undeath: Slow Death, Time, and Affective Suspension

If the prison and Woodbury arcs define the immunitary and systemic architecture of the world, their subsequent repetition across the series defines its temporal and affective texture. The survivors' existence unfolds within what Lauren Berlant calls slow death—"the physical wearing out of a population and the deterioration of people in that population that is very nearly a defining condition of their experience and historical existence." The condition is not an event but a state: a temporality of ongoing attrition in which life is sustained through depletion. **The Walking Dead** enacts this state both narratively and formally, producing a phenomenology of undeath that mirrors the ontological structure already established.

1. Temporal Suspension and the Collapse of Event

Berlant's analysis of slow death begins from the observation that modern life organizes itself around endurance rather than transformation. Time ceases to be progressive; it becomes administrative. In **The Walking Dead**, this temporal suspension is not thematic but structural. Each major arc—farm, prison, Alexandria, Hilltop, Commonwealth—follows the same pattern: settlement, fortification, breach, exodus, repetition. No teleological movement occurs; each cycle reinstates the same conditions under a new name.

This repetition is reinforced at the level of cinematic form. The series employs long-duration establishing shots, muted color grading, and editing rhythms that privilege continuity over climax. The effect is temporal homogenization: days and seasons blur into a single ongoing present. As **Describing the Zombie** argues, undeath is characterized by "persistence without closure," and the series' structure performs that condition precisely. The apocalypse never ends because it was never an event to begin with; it is the mode of existence that results when the capacity for ending has been lost.

The survivors' idiom reflects this reorientation of time. Phrases such as "We keep going," "Just one more day," and "This is what we do now"

punctuate dialogue across seasons. These are not expressions of hope but affirmations of ongoingness—the reduction of meaning to continuity. Temporal agency has been replaced by temporal maintenance, and history has become indistinguishable from duration.

2. Affective Flattening and the Exhaustion of Feeling

The affective corollary of this temporal structure is flattening. Emotional expression in **The Walking Dead** diminishes across seasons: early episodes contain moments of horror and grief; later seasons are characterized by monotone delivery and procedural affect. This progression is not a failure of character development but a representation of the affective economy proper to undeath. When life is organized entirely around survival, emotion loses its differential function—it no longer mediates relation but registers mechanical continuity.

Berlant's concept of the impasse—the space "where the usual frames of reference for desire and social belonging have dissolved but nothing has replaced them"—provides a precise description of this affective landscape. The survivors inhabit the impasse as a mode of being. Joy, grief, and rage appear as temporary spikes within a baseline of exhaustion. Even love, as between Glenn and Maggie or Michonne and Rick, operates as a survival technology rather than as relational excess. The emotional field is thus homologous with the physiological state of the zombie: minimal excitation sufficient only to sustain motion.

In the later seasons, this flattening extends to the viewer's experience. The serial form produces habituation; moments of violence lose intensity through repetition. What remains is a muted attentiveness—a mode of watching akin to the survivors' own vigilance. The show thereby reproduces in its spectators the phenomenology it depicts: the audience, like the characters, lives on in the state of managed depletion.

3. Social Contiguity Without Relation

As **Describing the Zombie** §3.3 notes, undeath is not solitude but contiguity without community. Bodies coexist spatially but without shared worldhood. This condition structures both the undead horde and the human settlements that oppose it. In the horde, proximity replaces relation: bodies move together without communication, their coordination purely kinetic. In the human communities, relation is similarly procedural—governed by rules, duties, and protocols rather than by meaning or desire.

The constant emphasis on quarantine, border maintenance, and surveillance reiterates Esposito's immunitary structure in social form. Contact is dangerous; intimacy must be regulated. This produces what might be called immunitary sociality: a community held together by mutual withdrawal. As in the horde, contiguity persists, but relation is absent. The series' visual language reinforces this equivalence: group scenes are shot in shallow focus, separating faces from background and isolating figures within the frame. Even in conversation, characters rarely share the same focal plane, as if the camera itself enacts the separation demanded by immunity.

4. The World as Administrative Horizon

Through these temporal, affective, and social configurations, the series constructs what the paper terms administrative worldhood: a reality in which all phenomena are modes of maintenance. Action sequences consist largely of repair (rebuilding fences, scavenging supplies, tending wounds), and narrative tension derives from the failure or success of these procedures. The world is thus not an environment in which life occurs but an infrastructure that requires constant upkeep to prevent its own dissolution. Existence becomes labor—an unending work of continuation.

This condition corresponds to what the earlier ontology calls the substitution of maintenance for event. Where relation to negation once produced meaning, only self-repair remains. The world of **The Walking Dead** is therefore not post-apocalyptic but ultra-administrative: a system that persists because it has no mechanism for ceasing. In phenomenological terms, it is the experience of time after the event of death has been deferred indefinitely.

5. Synthesis

Dimension	Theoretical Reference	Manifestation in **The Walking Dead**
Temporality	Berlant, §3.1 of **Describing the Zombie**	Cyclic narrative, absence of closure
Affect	Berlant's impasse	Procedural emotional tone, viewer habitu
Social Form	Esposito, Simondon	Quarantine, shallow-focus group scenes
Worldhood	Foucault, Heidegger	Continuous repair, infrastructural life

Through these convergent mechanisms, **The Walking Dead** realizes the phenomenological dimension of the zombie ontology: a world in which vitality remains, but experience—temporal, emotional, and communal—has

ceased to differentiate. The result is a lived form of unfinished death, the experiential correlate to the theoretical structure defined earlier. Life persists, but the conditions for living have disappeared.

VII. Governance as Ontology: The Commonwealth and the Completion of Undeath

The final phase of **The Walking Dead** introduces the Commonwealth, a post-apocalyptic polity of roughly fifty thousand inhabitants, complete with bureaucracy, law, military, and class hierarchy. It appears at first as restoration—the return of order, the reorganization of civil life after catastrophe. Yet closer analysis reveals that the Commonwealth represents not renewal but the ontological consummation of the processes traced throughout the series: the total internalization of survival as form of being. Where earlier arcs depicted the immunitary logic of self-preservation and the phenomenological exhaustion of slow death, the Commonwealth institutionalizes these dynamics as the organizing principle of existence itself.

1. From Biopolitical Management to Ontological Structure

In the Commonwealth, every aspect of life has become a function of governance. Citizens are classified by occupation; work assignments correspond to pre-apocalypse professions. This ordering reproduces what Foucault described as the normative function of biopower—the inscription of productive life into a regulatory system that defines normality through continuity. To be alive in the Commonwealth is to be administratively legible. Those who cannot be classified—the unemployed, the displaced, the resistant—are relegated to the outskirts of the city or to penal labor camps. Death is no longer the limit of life but its regulatory instrument: an event controlled and distributed to maintain equilibrium.

This system demonstrates what **Describing the Zombie** §4.3 names governance as ontology. The state no longer exists to protect life; life itself exists as the object through which the state sustains its being. The Commonwealth does not merely exercise power over its citizens; it is constituted by their maintenance. Its material infrastructures—electricity, food distribution, policing—are ontological functions, ensuring not meaning but duration. In this sense, the polity embodies the zombie condition at the scale of the social: vitality without reflexivity, order without world.

2. Necropolitical Sovereignty and the Administration of Death

Mbembe's analysis of necropower clarifies the ethical and political dimension of this structure. Where Foucault's biopolitics concerns the production and optimization of life, necropolitics concerns the organization of death as an ongoing practice. The Commonwealth's governance is explicitly necropolitical. Its ruling class decides which populations must die—the "expendable" workers in the labor camps—to sustain the illusion of prosperity for the core citizens. When Pamela Milton orders her soldiers to fire on protesters "for the greater good," she enacts Mbembe's thesis directly: sovereignty defined by the right to decide whose death preserves the system.

Visually, the Commonwealth's iconography mirrors this necropolitical logic. The color white dominates—uniforms, architecture, banners—signaling purification and control. Public celebrations, parades, and executions occur in the same spaces, collapsing civic ritual and sacrificial theater. The camera often frames the city through surveillance angles—high observation towers, drones, telescopic sights—reproducing the visual regime of the disciplinary society. The world that began in a hospital corridor ends as a city built entirely from those corridors, scaled to civilization.

3. Immunitary Society and Auto-Immunity at the Level of the State

Esposito's immunitary paradigm reappears here as the structural principle of government. The Commonwealth's stability depends on internalizing the mechanisms of exclusion: constant screening, segregation of classes, and rhetoric of "safety." The result is systemic auto-immunity—the polity preserves itself by reproducing the conditions of its own disintegration. Every rebellion, every purge, every tightening of security feeds the state's ontological necessity. Pamela's rule collapses not because her policies fail but because they succeed: the society becomes so immunized that it can no longer generate new norms of life, corresponding precisely to Canguilhem's definition of pathology.

The episode "Acts of God" illustrates this dynamic in condensed form. When a swarm of locusts devours the Commonwealth's crops, the state responds by diverting military resources from food distribution to riot control. The environmental crisis becomes a political crisis, but the administrative response remains constant: intensify regulation. The event that could have restored relation to world—an encounter with nature's otherness—is absorbed as another occasion for self-preservation. The system's closure against rela-

tion is total.

4. Collapse of Individuation and the Administrative Subject

The inhabitants of the Commonwealth, including its protagonists, display the same Simondonian failure of individuation previously identified in the prison arc, but now as institutional ontology. Occupations replace identities; functions replace relations. Characters who once embodied ethical agency (Eugene, Rosita, Mercer) now operate as components in the system's machinery. Their actions, even when rebellious, remain within the administrative horizon: investigation, negotiation, documentation. Revolt becomes bureaucratic procedure. The self no longer differentiates through relation but is defined by position within the total process of management. The human, in this schema, is merely the reflex of governance.

5. Ethical Remainders: Finitude Reintroduced

The final episodes juxtapose this totalization with moments that briefly reintroduce finitude—Carl's letters (retrospectively), Rosita's voluntary death, Maggie's refusal to kill Negan. Each gesture reactivates what **Describing the Zombie** §4.6 terms relation through negation: the recognition that to live meaningfully requires the capacity to die. Rosita's decision to reveal her bite only after saving her child restores agency to mortality; death becomes act rather than process. Maggie's statement, "I can't forgive you, but I'm not killing you," transforms justice from immunitary elimination to relational acknowledgment. These exceptions do not overturn the world's logic but delineate its limit, demonstrating that ethics survives only as momentary resistance within governance's ontology.

6. Synthesis

Theoretical Framework	Commonwealth Manifestation	Ontologica
Foucault – Biopolitics	Occupational hierarchy, surveillance infrastructure	Life rende
Mbembe – Necropolitics	Executions, labor camps, differential exposure to death	Sovereignt
Esposito – Immunity	Class segregation, rhetoric of "safety"	Preservati
Canguilhem – Pathology	Systemic stasis, administrative repetition	Life functi
Simondon – Individuation	Role fixation, bureaucratic selfhood	Relation c
Describing the Zombie §4.3	The state as total management	Governanc

Through the Commonwealth, **The Walking Dead** articulates the final state of unfinished death: a society in which the preservation of life has

become indistinguishable from its annihilation. The biopolitical apparatus that once administered life as resource has expanded to fill all of existence. No external world remains, only the recursive maintenance of the system itself.

7. Ontological Conclusion

At this terminal point, the series achieves the condition defined in **Describing the Zombie** as the "completion of undeath." The zombie is no longer an external figure but the structure of being itself. Every institution, emotion, and body operates under the same logic: vitality without relation, existence without end. The Commonwealth's eventual collapse does not signify liberation but the exhaustion of management—the moment when the system's self-preservation can no longer be sustained materially. Even then, the series' final montage reinstates the same order at a smaller scale: Daryl riding into the wilderness, Judith repeating, "We're the ones who live." The phrase, in this context, is not affirmation but axiom—the ontological statement of a world that has converted survival into being.

VIII. Serial Form and the Ontology of Unfinished Death

Across its eleven seasons and multiple spinoffs, **The Walking Dead** does not simply depict a world of undeath—it performs it. Every theoretical operation previously traced—biopolitical management, necropolitical governance, immunitary containment, affective exhaustion, and the failure of individuation—reappears at the level of form. The series itself functions as an administrative organism: a medium that sustains its own continuity through repetition, variation, and exhaustion. It is, in this respect, not merely a narrative of undeath but an artifact of it—a cultural system that survives by reproducing the very logic it critiques.

1. Seriality as Administrative Temporality

Television seriality, especially in its contemporary streaming and franchise iterations, is structurally aligned with the temporal regime of slow death. As Berlant notes, slow death is characterized by endurance without telos. In **The Walking Dead**, the serial form becomes an ontological principle: the impossibility of conclusion. The series repeats the same arcs—community formation, crisis, dissolution, exile—not as narrative redundancy but as the

necessary rhythm of survival. Each "new" setting (farm, prison, Alexandria, Commonwealth) is a restatement of the same immunitary structure.

From the perspective of **Describing the Zombie** §3.1, this repetition constitutes a medium-specific manifestation of "time without event." The apocalypse has no terminus; every season begins after the end. The show's refusal to produce finality, even in its conclusion, exemplifies what the earlier paper called the administrative temporality of undeath: a duration that persists precisely because it cannot end.

2. Production Ecology and Biopolitical Continuation

At the industrial level, **The Walking Dead*'s longevity—over a decade of continuous production—illustrates biopolitical optimization in the cultural domain. AMC's expansion into multiple spinoffs (*Fear the Walking Dead**, **World Beyond**, **Dead City**, **Daryl Dixon**) mirrors the logic of cellular replication: each series derives vitality from the previous, sustaining the franchise's metabolism. This economic and institutional replication operates analogously to Foucault's population logic—the dispersal of life into quantifiable, manageable units. The franchise thus becomes an organism that survives through differentiation without change, a networked system of vital continuance.

At this level, the distinction between diegetic survival (the survivors' persistence) and productional survival (the network's prolongation) disappears. Both instantiate the same structure: life that continues through management. Cultural production itself becomes undead, a process that persists because it cannot cease without erasing its own ground of value.

3. Affective Economy and Viewer Habituation

The affective flattening observed within the diegesis (Section VI) extends to the audience. Repeated exposure to death, crisis, and repair produces desensitization. Viewers learn to inhabit the same emotional economy as the characters—vigilant, fatigued, minimally responsive. This is not a failure of engagement but an effect of medium: the series conditions its spectators into the phenomenology of undeath. As the paper's §3 argued, affect in such a system is no longer expression but residue: the minimal excitation necessary to sustain attention.

This habituation also reproduces Esposito's immunitary relation between text and viewer. Spectators are "exposed" to death and suffering but in a regulated, safe form. The series inoculates its audience against the shock of

mortality through endless controlled repetition, achieving aesthetic immunity. The viewer's endurance mirrors the survivors': both persist within a system that manages their affective thresholds to ensure ongoing participation.

4. Narrative Self-Replication and Ontological Closure

By the Commonwealth arc, narrative recursion becomes reflexive. Characters within the diegesis begin founding new settlements, repeating older models of governance with slight variations—each promising to "do it right this time." This gesture mirrors the production logic of the series itself. As **Describing the Zombie** §4.3 posited, governance at this stage becomes ontological rather than political: the act of reproduction is the form of existence. The Commonwealth rebuilds the hospital, the prison, and the farm simultaneously within its administrative architecture. Similarly, AMC rebuilds **The Walking Dead** across multiple spinoffs, each a controlled mutation of the same genetic material. Repetition becomes the ontological mode of cultural being under late modernity: the undead logic of management extended into art.

5. Ethical Residue and the Question of Finitude

Throughout **Describing the Zombie**, finitude functions as the minimal condition for relation and therefore for meaning. Within **The Walking Dead**, finitude is both thematically and structurally foreclosed. Deaths occur continually, but none produce closure; each loss is absorbed into the maintenance of continuity. Only isolated acts—Carl's suicide, Rosita's self-sacrifice, Maggie's renunciation of revenge—momentarily reintroduce relation to death as event. Yet even these moments are assimilated by the serial system, recoded as narrative transitions. Ethical rupture becomes content.

The series finale consolidates this condition. Judith's statement, "We're the ones who live," functions as ontological declaration rather than moral lesson. It articulates the formula of unfinished death: life understood as indefinite continuation. The final montage of settlements rebuilding after crisis reaffirms survival as the sole remaining value. What once began as an allegory of apocalypse ends as an affirmation of administration.

6. The Series as Empirical Verification of the Ontology

Ontological Element (from **Describing the Zombie**)	Serial Correlate in **The Walking Dead**
Vitality without Reflexivity	Continuous seasons, unending production
Immunity as Life Logic	Franchising, genre standardization
Pathology (Canguilhem)	Cultural stagnation, narrative exhaustion
Failure of Individuation (Simondon)	Functional characters, type continuity
Phenomenology of Slow Death (Berlant)	Viewer habituation, affective fatigue
Governance as Ontology (§4.3)	Commonwealth and production apparatus

Taken together, these correspondences confirm the ontological reading advanced across this study. **The Walking Dead** is not a symbolic meditation on death but a procedural instantiation of life's transformation into administration. At the level of content, it portrays survival; at the level of form, it enacts it. Its continuation across media and decades demonstrates that unfinished death is not merely a fictional condition but the logic of cultural production itself.

7. Terminal Observation

In closing, the series' persistence offers an empirical index of the metaphysical claim advanced in **Describing the Zombie**: that the modern world has achieved a form of being in which death no longer concludes life but perpetuates it administratively. **The Walking Dead** survives its own exhaustion, proliferating through sequels and derivative media not because it renews meaning but because it cannot end without violating the ontology it depicts. Its final gesture—a promise of continuation—translates a philosophical axiom into popular form:

> Life, having lost relation to death, endures as the maintenance of its own remainder.

IX. Conclusion — The Walking Dead as Empirical Ontology of Unfinished Death

The preceding analysis has traced, through successive theoretical frameworks, the progressive saturation of **The Walking Dead** by the ontological condition formulated in **Describing the Zombie**:

> Zombie = vitality reflexivity = persistence without relation.

Across its narrative, formal, and industrial dimensions, the series demonstrates that the zombie is not a figure contained within fiction but the operative structure of life under late modernity. What begins in the hospital corridor of "Days Gone Bye" as an image of biopolitical administration concludes in the Commonwealth as a world entirely constituted by management. The arc that the series traces is not from catastrophe to recovery but from event to system—from apocalypse as rupture to apocalypse as order.

1. Synthesis of Theoretical Trajectories

Conceptual Axis	Theoretical Source	Manifestation in **The Walking Dea**
Biopower	Foucault	Hospital surveillance, disciplinary arc
Bare Life	Agamben	Quarantine, lawful killing
Necropolitics	Mbembe	Barn massacre, executions, Commonw
Immunity / Auto-immunity	Esposito	Fences, purges, class segregation
Pathology	Canguilhem	Routine maintenance, inability to inn
Failure of Individuation	Simondon	Walker horde, bureaucratic subjects
Slow Death	Berlant	Serial repetition, affective flattening
Governance as Ontology	**Describing the Zombie** §4.3	The Commonwealth and franchise for

This matrix demonstrates that each theoretical apparatus identifies a different register of the same transformation: the substitution of relation by administration. From individual embodiment to collective governance to media form, life's reflexivity—the capacity to relate to its own finitude—has been replaced by the procedural continuation of systems. The zombie, in this schema, is not antagonist but paradigm: the exemplary being of a world organized to persist beyond its own meaning.

2. The Series as Verification of Ontological Claim

The Walking Dead verifies the ontology of unfinished death not through allegory but through structure. At the diegetic level, its world operates entirely through immunitary and necropolitical mechanisms: survival achieved by replication of control. At the phenomenological level, its characters and viewers inhabit the same temporality of slow death—duration without telos, emotion without modulation. At the industrial level, its production and franchising repeat the same principle: continuity as value. Across all scales, the series functions as a model of life prolonged after relation, confirming that the zombie is the form of being appropriate to late modern governance.

3. Ontological Implications

Three implications follow from this analysis:

1. Death as Withdrawn Limit: Death no longer functions as negation or event but as process. It has been internalized into the maintenance of life—appearing as sanitation, quarantine, attrition, and obsolescence. The limit that once gave life meaning now sustains it administratively.

2. Life as System: Life has ceased to operate as self-forming relation and has become the reproduction of conditions. The living organism, the social body, and the cultural artifact each persist by replicating their own operational logic. This is the ontological equivalent of Esposito's auto-immunity: existence that survives through its own subtraction.

3. Relation as Ethical Residue: Only in moments where finitude re-enters—Rosita's acceptance of death, Maggie's renunciation of vengeance—does relation briefly reappear. These instances confirm the rule by providing its exception: that meaning is possible only where ending is possible.

4. Formal Conclusion

The structural and thematic convergence of these dynamics substantiates the central claim of **Describing the Zombie**: that the zombie condition is not a deviation from life but its logical completion under modernity's biopolitical order. **The Walking Dead** provides the empirical field in which this completion becomes visible. Its continuity over eleven seasons and multiple media platforms functions as a living archive of the ontology of unfinished death: a serialized demonstration that the will to preserve life, when generalized into governance, abolishes the possibility of living.

The final line—Judith's assertion, "We're the ones who live"—therefore constitutes not triumph but tautology. To live, in this world, is simply to persist. The statement collapses ontology into administration, announcing that being has become equivalent to maintenance. The series closes where the concept of undeath begins: in the affirmation of life as its own remainder.

5. Coda: From Representation to Condition

At this point, the distinction between **The Walking Dead** as representation and the world that produces it becomes negligible. The show's ontological structure mirrors the social, economic, and political systems that sustain its existence. Late-capitalist cultural production, global media franchising,

and algorithmic audience retention all operate by the same principle: the elimination of finitude through continuous management. The undead are not on-screen entities but indices of a world that has replaced relation with operation, meaning with sustainability.

In this sense, **The Walking Dead** serves as both object and demonstration of the ontology of unfinished death. It is the experiment by which culture verifies its own metaphysical condition—a condition in which life, unable to end, has become indistinguishable from its own administration.

> The zombie, as defined in "Describing the Zombie," is no longer confined to the domain of horror. It is the general form of existence under governance—a being whose persistence is guaranteed, and whose end is therefore impossible. The Walking Dead does not depict this truth; it is its realization.